

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

WHAT'S SO DIFFERENT ABOUT ANCIENT GREEK AND ROMAN SEX?

Sex is everywhere. People in every culture, at every time in history, have engaged in sexual behavior, whether for purposes of procreation or pleasure or both. Yet sex can be difficult to talk about and even more challenging to analyze as a feature of a particular culture. This difficulty arises both from a tendency, in many cultures, to treat sexual behaviors as private, and from our own ideas and preconceptions about sex, sexual behaviors, and sexual identities. First, because sex is a natural part of life, we tend to think that the particular forms of sex that are prevalent in our society are also natural. Though we may not put it in exactly these terms, we assume that certain kinds of sex are normal and others are not normal, and that these value judgments are universal and transcend both time and space. Second, we think of sex as particularly private; while we think we know what normal sex is, and what most people do, we generally do not want to talk to our neighbors about their sex lives. This sense of privacy serves to hide common sexual practices that may not fit the norm at the same time that it fuels anxiety about such practices. Because we think of sex as belonging to private life, moreover, we sometimes do not see that we deal with sex in a public way all the time: our popular culture, from teen romance movies to supermarket magazines, is littered with artifacts that describe in great detail and variety how we think about sex in our lives.

When we look closely at some of the ancient Greek and Roman conversations about sex, most of these rules also apply to the ways that they discussed sexual practice. The ancient Greeks and Romans thought of certain kinds of sex as normal or abnormal and criticized some abnormal practices as unnatural or shameful; many aspects of sexual life were considered private and therefore not spoken about. When we scrutinize the

ways in which they did speak about sex, however, we rapidly discover that the Greeks and Romans speak in some ways that are foreign to us. In fact, we may be initially a bit shocked at how publicly they seem to discuss what are, for us, embarrassingly private moments. Their sense of what should be kept private and what constitutes an acceptable public forum for sexual discussions is not exactly the same as ours. Further confusing the issue is the fact that Greek and Roman conventions about sex itself are not always the same as ours, so that sexual content may appear so different from our own experience that we do not understand it at all.

It is useful to begin by emphasizing that we are not as reticent about sex as we sometimes think. The modern West also has a long tradition of talking about sex, though we do so in a series of metaphors and images that have become conventional; such metaphors tend to reduce the shock value of these public conversations. The distance of even a few hundred years also serves to reduce the impact of what were, at one time, quite racy discussions. To get a bit of perspective on this problem, consider the last lines of a famous love poem from the English tradition:

The Grave's a fine and private place,
But none I think do there embrace.
Now therefore, while the youthful hew
Sits on thy skin like morning glew,
And while thy willing Soul transpires
At every pore with instant Fires
Now let us sport us while we may;
And now, like am'rous birds of prey,
Rather at once our Time devour,
Than languish in his slow-chapt pow'r.
Let us roll all our Strength, and all,
Our sweetness, up into one Ball:
And tear our Pleasures with rough strife,
Through the Iron gates of Life.
Thus, though we cannot make our Sun
Stand still, yet we will make him run.

I first read these lines, as I suspect many Americans did, in high school. They are from Andrew Marvell's "To His Coy Mistress" and are the closing part of the speaker's argument, in which he tries to persuade his beloved to waste no time in going to bed with him. Though there is no explicit description of sex—quite—the imagery of "Let us roll all our Strength, and all, / Our sweetness, up into one Ball: / And tear our Pleasures with rough

strife / Through the Iron gates of Life" does not leave much to the imagination. These lines also provide some fairly standard metaphors for the passion of love: the speaker compares his beloved's youth to the freshness of morning, and in the next lines, he imagines that she feels like she is on fire. It all adds up to an argument for haste, a desire on the part of the speaker to enjoy sex while both he and his beloved are young; the poem is a celebration of the passion of youth in the face of the fact that time will not stop at this fleeting, precious moment. If his beloved waits too long, both speaker and beloved will be dead—and then it will be too late: "The Grave's a fine and private place, / But none, I think, do there embrace."

Compare that fairly explicit reading experience to the following poem of Strato, a Greek author of erotic poetry, writing at the time of the Roman emperor Hadrian:

"Know the right time," said one of the seven sages, Philippus.
 For all things are loveliest at their prime.
 Even the cucumber is valued, when first seen on the garden's border.
 But too ripe, it becomes fodder for pigs.¹ (*Greek Anthology* 12.197)

The first thing the modern reader might notice is that this poem does not seem all that sexy. If it were not found in a book of fairly explicit love poetry, she might not even think of it as being about love or sex. It is found in such a collection, however, and that fact begins to open up some familiar patterns of thought. The speaker of the poem indicates urgency, and the reader might recognize something like Marvell's argument in the line "all things are loveliest at their prime." In fact, the poem is in the form of an argument, and much like Marvell's poem, the argument is that the beloved (Philippus) should not wait to have sex. Even the gardening imagery is not entirely foreign to us. Though contemporary poetry does not often compare the beloved to a cucumber, the idea of a lover as a flower (as in Burns's famous "My love is like a red, red rose") is familiar enough.

The temptation, then, is to read the preceding poem and think that it is not so far from the love poetry of the English tradition—it is just another poem urging the beloved to "seize the day." Unfortunately, the Greek poem hides some meanings from modern readers, simply because we are not steeped in the poetic tradition from which it comes. First, the speaker (who is male) is addressing his little poem to a person named Philippus (also male). In our terms, that makes this a homosexual poem, though as we will see, that terminology does not quite work for the ancient Greeks. Leaving that issue aside for the moment, we must understand that in the Greek system of erotic relationships that this poem celebrates, it was con-

sidered quite normal for older men (30 to 50 years old or even older) to try to seduce young men — that is, men between the ages of, say, 13 and 20. More specifically, there is a concrete physical limit at which these young men cease to be attractive, and that limit is the appearance of secondary sexual characteristics, especially hair on the cheeks and buttocks. So, for example, Strato writes in another poem,

Especially among them see how Milesius blooms,
As a rose resplendent with sweet-smelling petals.
But perhaps he does not know that, as a fair flower by the heat,
So young beauty is destroyed by a hair. (*Greek Anthology* 12.195)

These beautiful young men are only attractive as *objects* of affection, so long as they are young. Once they become older, they are supposed to switch roles and become the older men who are attracted to the younger ones. Moreover, this shift of roles is accompanied by a rather strict shift in sexual roles as well: the lover (the older man) is assumed to be the penetrating partner, and the beloved (the younger) to be the penetrated. (I will examine these roles in more nuance and detail later.) Once a man grows hair on certain parts of his body, he is no longer the beautiful darling sought by all the older men, and instead he finds that he must become the pursuer rather than the pursued. Since the age of attractiveness is tightly defined, there must always have been more men pursuing than youths being pursued, and the loss of one's physical attractiveness must have carried with it a certain loss of status. It is a transition that is described in harsh terms in many of the poems of the *Greek Anthology*.

So it turns out that what looked at first like a similarity between our own tradition and the Greek contains something a little unfamiliar. Strato's poem is not simply saying "Gather ye Rose-buds while ye may" (to quote Herrick's "To the Virgins, to Make Much of Time"), but is rather pointing to a specific moment in Philippus's life that is fast approaching. Soon, he will not be the valued cucumber on the edge of the garden, but, once past his prime, fodder for pigs. The sentiment is similar to that in Marvell's poem, but the specific cultural associations are very different.

All of the preceding may seem a bit shocking. But I have saved the greatest shock of all for last. Strato's poem is, by modern standards, quite obscene. For, as it turns out, it relies on two sexual images that were standard for the Greeks but are foreign to the later Western tradition. Cucumbers are used occasionally (as we might guess) as a metaphor for a man's phallus, and pigs are a regular metaphor for female genitalia. Suddenly, the poem takes on a completely different, and surprisingly graphic, meaning.

What the speaker is warning is this: "Right now, Philippus, your 'cucumber' is attractive to men like me. But soon, when it grows larger, it will only be useful for having sex with women. And won't that be a shame? You'd better have sex with me—a man—while you still have time."

So now the poem is not only about the sense of urgency that Philippus ought to feel, but it also gives a succinct, elegant snapshot of the different kinds of sex that the Greeks were interested in. It suggests, further, a specific value system that is not quite ours either. At the very least, the poem suggests that Philippus ought to prefer sex with the (male) speaker of the poem to the kind of sex he will have later, with women, when he becomes an adult male.

Some of my readers will be surprised by what I have just explained, and some amused. But in any case, the ancient Greek and Roman systems of erotics were different from ours (and from each other). When we understand the ways in which they were different, their erotic poetry looks rather different from ours, too. And whatever one thinks of the Greek and Roman systems of erotics and of their love poetry, we can only understand the latter when we look unflinchingly at the former. In the next few chapters, we look at a vast tradition of erotic writings, in contexts ranging from the legal system to comedy to love poetry. In the end, the reader will come to understand a system of erotic life that is, in some ways, not like our own and, in other ways, surprisingly similar, but in any case, coherent, interesting, and a real pleasure to study.

FIRST PRINCIPLES

This is a book about ancient Greek and Roman sexual practices and attitudes. As the brief example given previously demonstrates, those practices and attitudes may be unfamiliar and even shocking to some of my readers. I should warn you, therefore, that my tolerance for discussion of sex is rather high, and I do not intend to flinch away from a literal description of what the Greeks and Romans said and did. If this material offends you, this book is not for you.

Those who are interested in what this book offers should know that this study is based on a virtual explosion of scholarly discussion on the topic of Greek and Roman sexuality that began, in a variety of venues, in the 1970s. Much of what I will have to say is still controversial, and I will, at times, refer to scholarly works with which my own views disagree. For the sake of the reader, I have kept footnotes to a minimum, and I refer only to a few of the recent and most relevant discussions of the issue at

hand. Scholars interested in a more thorough treatment of the secondary literature should turn to the works suggested for further reading. Readers should be aware, however, that most of the texts I refer to are now easily available in an excellent collection of translations edited by Thomas Hubbard.² Though I have translated most of the sources in this book myself, interested readers may want to turn to Hubbard to read fuller versions of the texts in reliable translations.

Before we begin, I wish to be clear about a few definitions. Three inter-related terms are paramount: sex, gender, and sexuality. When I talk about *sex* (as in “the sex of the speaker is female”), I am referring to the biologically determined indicators of human distinction on the basis of sex. Although modern science has blurred the permanence and significance of these indicators considerably in recent decades—a person can choose to undergo a sex change operation and undergo hormone therapy in order to change his or her biological sex—in common practice, this is a matter of genitalia. Men have penises, and women have vaginas. Recent work has shown that this distinction, which most people take as “natural,” is not nearly as clear or as universal as it is assumed to be; roughly one in 1,500 to 2,000 individuals is born with ambiguous genitalia (the level of ambiguity varying widely). Even at the level of genitalia, then, a clearly defined human dimorphism is a matter of cultural belief and, in some cases, medical intervention. In the ancient world, these distinctions similarly were not crystal clear: ancient Greece and Rome knew of a type of person known as a *hermaphrodite*, a person with ambiguous sexual organs. (In the modern world, the term *intersexed* is preferred.) On a deeper level of biology, this distinction is a matter of chromosomes: XX or XY, though in fact science has again established that sexual characteristics are determined by markers on many more chromosomes than these two.

When I speak of gender, I should be clear that I am not referring to a biological state but rather a matter of cultural definition. *Gender* refers to the cultural interpretation that is ascribed to the biological markers of sex. In other words, certain traits and behaviors are identified as masculine or feminine. The important thing to remember about gender is that the traits that are valued are not necessarily the same across time and culture. Greek men viewed Persian men as suspiciously feminine, in part because (unlike the Greeks) Persian men wore pants. Long hair is still something of a feminine trait in our society, though men can wear their hair long if they are willing to deal with the social pressures that accompany this slight deviation from the norm. Many other signs are less obvious, though no less powerful: studies have shown that in modern-day America, women move their heads when they talk more than men, and they tend to end their sen-

tences with a slight upward pitch, whereas men end theirs with a downward one. Try doing the opposite sometime (i.e., if you are a man, raise your voice at the end of your sentences and bob your head around while you talk), and you will quickly see what I mean. Again, because gender markers are by definition culturally determined, it is possible for an individual to create and maintain a gender identity that is at variance with his or her biological sex. As we will see, some individuals in the ancient world seem to have engaged in creative manipulations of gender identity.

Sexuality is, at the most basic level, the cultural interpretation of a person's sexual identity, determined by whether or not a person arranges her sexual life according to the norms of her society. Again, it is important to note that these social norms are not fixed across time and place. There have been, and are still today, many societies in which it is normal for younger men to engage in sexual activities with older males. Though such men would, in the modern West, be considered gay (or at least bisexual), within the context of their own societies, such a term simply makes no sense. They are not thought of as belonging to any particular sexual orientation or sexuality; they are simply young men.

Sexuality, then, is the most complex of these three terms, in large part because it interacts with both of the other two; that is, the definitions of gender play a large role in determining what is appropriate sexual behavior for an individual. In the modern West, men who prefer to engage in sex with other men, rather than women, are considered homosexual. Whether true or not, one prevalent set of assumptions in our society is that gay men are less masculine than straight men, and gay women are presumed to be, in some senses, more masculine than straight women. So a violation of sexual norms means, in effect, that an individual runs a risk on two cultural axes at once: a gay person can be marginalized because he or she is gay (i.e., discrimination based on sexuality) or marginalized as inappropriately gendered (i.e., discrimination based on perceived gender slippage).

All of that is something of an oversimplification. In the modern world, one's sexuality is much more than the outside world's perception of one's sexual role. We also think of sexuality in terms of identity: a person is not just homosexual or heterosexual, but he or she is *a* homosexual or *a* heterosexual. The object of one's desire—and whether she/he is of the same or the opposite sex—becomes a powerful indicator of what kind of person the desiring subject is, and is commonly understood to be a key that unlocks deeply secret aspects of that person's psyche. Being homo- or heterosexual also expands outward to suggest a person's orientation toward the world and toward culture at large; once thought of as an iden-

tity, sexuality takes on the power to define a lifestyle, that is, it becomes an attitude toward society that goes well beyond sexual activity.

As we have already seen, the terms most commonly used today when we think about categories of sexuality simply will not work when we discuss ancient Greece and Rome. If we begin with the presumption that the Greeks and Romans divided the sexual world into homo- and heterosexual, then we are left with rather curious but inevitable conclusions: that virtually every man in Athens was gay, or at least bisexual, but that at the same time, the Greeks and Romans expressed, in some kinds of texts, extreme forms of homophobia. A simpler and more reasonable assumption is that the Greeks and Romans thought of sexual roles differently than we do—that, in effect, their sexual universe was oriented on a different set of axes than ours is.

Even more fundamentally, it is far from clear that the Greeks and Romans thought of sexual roles as sexualities—that is, as deeply seated internal elements of one's psyche that determine not only sexual roles but also character and lifestyle. For reasons that I will discuss later in this chapter, Michel Foucault has argued that that notion of sexuality only comes into existence in the nineteenth century, as a necessary product of the discursive power of the field of psychology. Foucault's thesis has been challenged, and it is certainly worth looking at those challenges closely; but for now, let us assume that it is an open question whether or not the Greeks and Romans had a category of thought that we can legitimately call "sexuality."

DOWN TO BASICS: PSEUDO-LUCIAN'S *Erotes*

All of this is somewhat difficult to discuss in the abstract, so I will turn now to a description and discussion of a specific text. Although most of this book is arranged in chronological order, the first text I discuss, pseudo-Lucian's *Erotes* (or *Loves*), is quite late. Most scholars put its composition in the years 200–300 CE. (Originally, it was thought to be the work of Lucian, an author of the second century CE. Experts now believe that it is not really his work, but since we do not know, in that case, whose work it is, we are forced to refer to the author as "pseudo-Lucian," that is, someone imitating the style of Lucian.) This text, written in Greek by someone living in the later Roman Empire, illustrates with particular clarity how the ancient sexual system was different from ours. Reading it allows us to deduce what the unstated social assumptions were behind a particular

piece of literature, and it serves as a useful springboard to examine how the Greeks and Romans thought of sex, and if they thought of sexuality at all.³

The form of pseudo-Lucian's *Erotes* is one that most modern readers are not familiar with. The text presents itself as a philosophical dialogue on the forms of love; that is, two speakers, Callicratidas (from Athens) and Charicles (from Corinth), hold a formal argument on the question of whether it is better to love boys (i.e., young men before the onset of adulthood) or women. Each of these speakers is interested in only one sex: Callicratidas loves boys, Charicles, women. It is tempting, therefore, to see them as representatives of homosexuality and heterosexuality, but as will become clear, that distinction breaks down on careful examination. This is a light-hearted and not terribly serious text, but one with clear literary pretensions. The author recalls, through several small allusions and references, various works of high Greek culture. The text is most clearly indebted to Plato's *Symposium* (discussed later in this book), in which Socrates recounts the teachings of Diotima on the topic of love in a more serious vein.

Before the formal debate even begins, it is clear that something other than our sexual value system is at play. A character named Lycinus is having a conversation with one Theomnestus, and in the course of their discussion, it comes out that each of them has his own unusual sexual preference. Theomnestus declares that Lycinus will make an impartial judge of the debate between Callicratidas and Charicles since he is not interested in sex with either boys or women (*Erotes* 4). Theomnestus, we learn in the next paragraph, is interested in sex with both. Lycinus compares Theomnestus's attitude with that of Callicratidas and Charicles, saying, "You who, thanks to your easy-going spirit, go sleepless and earn double wages, 'One as a herdsman of cattle, another as a tender of white flocks.'"⁴ (This last sentence is a quotation from *Odyssey* 10.84–85.) What is remarkable about this description to many modern readers is that Theomnestus's bisexuality is not particularly remarkable and certainly has no overtones of immorality. Rather, describing him through a learned literary allusion, Lycinus likens Theomnestus to a man who has two jobs—and jokingly suggests that because he is willing to sleep with either sex, he does not get much sleep.

The two speakers who frame the dialogue proper, then, provide the reader with two Greek sexual types, one of whom is a bit strange in avoiding sex altogether (Lycinus), and the other of whom is normal, if overly active (Theomnestus). What defines their sexual behavior, however, is not whether they choose to sleep with boys or women, but rather whether they are interested in sex at all. One is, one is not, but the one who does enjoy

sex is presumed to enjoy sex with both men and women, and this aspect of his sexual behavior is not seen as problematic. Between the two of them, Lycinus and Theomnestus define the poles of an axis on which every Greek and Roman man had to locate himself.

By contrast, the two men who have the debate about the preferable form of love are described in terms that make it clear that each of them is really quite an odd duck. Callicratidas, the Athenian, is only interested in boys. We might assume that his preference is abnormal, and it is. But Callicratidas's desire is not abnormal because it is homoerotic; in fact, it is worth noting that Lycinus describes him as "a man of straightforward ways. For he was preeminent among the leading figures in public speaking and in this forensic oratory of ours" (*Erotes* 9). There is evidently no concern about his love for boys as such. What is odd about his preference is that he loves boys exclusively. Later in the dialogue, Callicratidas engages in a misogynistic diatribe that is extreme, even for an ancient Greek.

Even more noticeable, though, is the fact that Charicles's predilection for women, and only women, is also thought of as abnormal. Here is how Lycinus describes his household:

Charicles, however, had in attendance a large band of dancing-girls and singing-girls and all his house was as full of women as if it were the Thesmophoria, with not the slightest trace of male presence except that here and there could be seen an infant boy or a superannuated old cook whose age could give even the jealous no cause for suspicion. (*Erotes* 10)

Charicles, whom we might be tempted to think of as heterosexual, is not just a normal guy. As in the case of Callicratidas, his exclusive preference is worthy of comment and thus marked as a bit bizarre. His house resembles the Thesmophoria, an annual festival of Demeter in which only women participated, itself set off from the normal activities of civic business. We do hear that Charicles allows very young and very old men in his household, and it is worth noting here that this exception to his rule is itself somewhat ambiguous. The men who are excluded from his household are those who are of a sexual age. But are they sexual as *objects* of desire, or as desiring subjects? The Greek translated literally says that he allows those "whose age held no suspicion of rivalry." But rivalry for whom—the women of the household, or for Charicles himself? I believe that Charicles allows no men in his house who might be *his* rival for the affection of his female attendants, but it is impossible to know for sure. The first point we must note about this debate, in any case, is clear: this is not an argu-

ment between a normal heterosexual and a less normal homosexual about whose kind of sex is better; rather, it is a disagreement between two men who are both odd in their strongly held preference for one kind of perfectly acceptable sex over the other. The grounds of the debate are simply not those that would occur in most public contexts in the modern West.

In the course of the debate itself, the speakers confirm the idea that this is an argument about two kinds of fully comparable and interchangeable sexual activity. Each of them discusses the characteristics and advantages of their preferred kind of love. Charicles begins with a set of arguments that are familiar: he suggests that in early days, before the corrupting influence of civilization, men had sex with women, as nature intended. It was only with the arrival of a more decadent time that men began having sex with boys, and "they were ashamed neither at what they did nor at what they had done to them, and, sowing their seed, to quote the proverb, on barren rocks they bought a little pleasure at the cost of great disgrace" (*Erotes* 20). He goes on to argue that animals do not engage in same-sex activity (*Erotes* 22). Then, anticipating that Callicratidas will rely on the philosophical precedent of Socrates, he argues that when the philosophers claim that their love for boys is really something more virtuous (i.e., love of beauty or virtue), they are giving "honorable names to dishonorable passions" (*Erotes* 24).

All of this sounds rather like a modern denunciation of homosexuality, which is often decried as "unnatural" (though in fact, same-sex sexual activity is not uncommon among cats, dogs, and other animals). We should note, however, that Charicles never suggests that feeling this sort of desire is "unnatural" (in the sense of "contrary to human nature") or unlikely; rather, his argument thus far is simply that, although we all feel such desires, we would do better not to act on them because they do not lead to the survival of the species. The more serious problem with such love affairs, he argues, is that they do not last very long because the beloved boy will inevitably grow up and cease to be an object of desire. Women, he says, are desirable "from maidenhood to middle age" (*Erotes* 25). But should a man pursue a man over the age of 20, Charicles argues, then things begin to be repugnant:

For then the limbs, being large and manly, are hard, the chins that once were soft are rough and covered with bristles, and the well-developed thighs are, as it were, sullied with hairs. And as for the parts less visible than these, I leave knowledge of them to you who have tried them! (*Erotes* 26)

In other words, love of women is better than love of boys because it lasts longer—and not because there is anything unusual or shameful (in this part of the argument) about feeling desire for boys.

Charicles continues on similar lines, arguing that there is a structural problem in affairs between men and boys, namely, that the boys derive no pleasure from the act of sex (*Erotes* 27). Ideally, Charicles argues, sexual preference should be mutual and reciprocal. Here we see clearly one of the assumptions that underlies the Greek sexual system being described; that is, while it is presumed that the active partner in the sexual relationship—the adult man—will derive pleasure from sex with either a woman or a boy, the boy, who is being penetrated, is presumed not to experience pleasure. He is understood, rather, to put up with the sexual imposition in return for other kinds of favors. Here, as we will see repeatedly in Greek and Roman texts, that which is shameful and considered deviant by the dominant culture is for a fully adult man to enjoy being penetrated. Penetrating, whether the object is a boy or a woman, is presumed pleasurable and normal.

Indeed, at the very end of his argument, Charicles indicates that in a fundamental way, the pleasure that the male subject experiences with a boy is interchangeable for that with a woman. His penultimate point is that women can be used like boys—that is, they can be penetrated anally—but that boys cannot be penetrated vaginally. While the overt point of this argument is that women provide “two paths to pleasure,” while a boy has only one (*Erotes* 27), the underlying understanding is that anal sex with a woman is more or less the same thing as with a boy.

Charicles does not oppose same-sex amours, then, on the sort of moralizing grounds that socially conservative individuals invoke today; rather, for him, there are specific aspects of the adult male–young man relationship that are disadvantageous. It is a relationship that does not result in procreation; it is necessarily of limited duration; and it is one-sided in the bestowal of pleasure. Of these three arguments, only the first one can be applied to the modern idea of homosexuality. Here, then, the Greeks are thinking differently than us.

Callicratidas responds first to Charicles’s charge that same-sex desire is unnatural. He concedes that sex with women is necessary as a means of procreation but then argues that, with the advent of civilization, we should not limit ourselves to this required act, but enjoy the results of the greater leisure that comes with an advance in human comfort. This argument reaches a conclusion with a comment about animals, answering Charicles’s earlier observation of their heteroerotic practice: “Lions do not have such a love, because they are not philosophers either” (*Erotes* 36). In

other words, same-sex sexual activity (between men) is one of the advantages of civilization—along with higher reasoning, better clothes, more elaborate foodstuffs, and all the rest that we enjoy now that life is a little less nasty, brutish, and short.

Callicratidas next tries to justify his idiosyncratic banishing of all women from his life, and he does so by again appealing to a notion of what is natural. Women, he points out, rely on artifice for their beauty, in the form of makeup, clothing, and jewelry. Boys, by contrast, live a life of unfeigned and natural valor:

He rises at dawn from his couch, washes away with pure water such sleep as still remains in his eyes, and after securing his shirt and his mantle pins at the shoulder, he leaves his father's hearth with eyes bent down and without facing the gaze of anyone. . . . Next come the glistening wrestling schools, where beneath the heat of the midday sun his developing body is covered in dust; then comes the sweat that pours forth from his toils in the contest, and next a quick bath and a sober meal suited to the activities that soon follow. . . . Who would not fall in love with such a youth? Whose eyesight could be so blind, whose mental processes so stunted? (*Erotes* 44–46)

In this argument, it is the boy's natural beauty, won by hard exercise and dedication to the study of virtue, that trumps the more artificial beauty of the heavily made-up and perfumed woman.

Finally, Callicratidas must respond to the argument that relationships with young men are not mutually pleasurable and are necessarily short-lived. He does so by invoking the image of Socrates, whose love for young men was presented (by Plato) as part of a program of virtuous instruction, from which the young men would benefit as they grew older. Indeed, Callicratidas says,

For, when the honorable love inbred in us from childhood matures to the manly age that is now capable of reason, the object of our long-standing affection gives love in return and it is difficult to detect which is the lover of which, since the image of the lover's tenderness has been reflected from the loved one as though from a mirror. (*Erotes* 48)⁵

Given this model for the love of young men, however, Callicratidas also acknowledges that it comes with a set of limits. He suggests that since such long-standing friendship is the goal of these relations, the lovers in such a relationship must keep their affections carefully under control: "Do not

for the sake of a brief pleasure squander lasting affection, nor till you've reached manhood show counterfeit feelings of affection, but worship heavenly Love and keep your emotions constant from boyhood to old age" (*Erotes* 49). This last set of comments is indicative of one of the core values of ancient Greek sexual practice. Far more than one's choice of erotic object, the ancient Greeks were concerned with the demonstration of temperance, or self-control.

The two speakers have made their case; at the close of the dialogue, Lycinus gives his judgment. He tries, briefly, to steer a middle course: he declares that all men should marry, but that only philosophers should be allowed to love boys for "perfect virtue grows least of all among women" (*Erotes* 51); that is, he accepts the philosophers' argument that their love of boys is a necessity since boys better embody virtue than women do. Though this has sometimes been taken as a victory for Callicratidas—and indeed Charicles seems to take it that way—the final section of the dialogue undercuts it significantly. For Theomnestus, our lover of both women and boys, has the last word, and he decrees that it would be unfair to require him to love boys but never enjoy them sexually (*Erotes* 53). Nor, he says, did Alcibiades arise from lying with Socrates "unassailed" (*Erotes* 54). At the close of the dialogue, then, Theomnestus insists on the physical aspect of men's love of boys and begins an argument to defend that aspect, suggesting that Achilles and Patroklos—the great heroic pair of the *Iliad*—were lovers as well as friends (*Erotes* 54).

I have described this dialogue at some length, quoted from it extensively, to give the reader a taste of what the ancient Greeks worried about when they worried about sex. Let me now summarize a few of the main assumptions that underlie this entertaining dialogue. First, we note that although both of the speakers hold exclusive erotic tastes—one loves only boys, the other only women—neither Lycinus nor the speakers assume that either of these positions is the social norm; rather, the dialogue could only take place as it does in a society that assumes that most men are interested in both boys and women. The question, then, is not why some percentage of the population is homosexual, but rather, of the commonly available and desirable options, which should men prefer? For the most part, moreover, the arguments for that preference are not cast in terms of one kind of love being inherently wrong; rather, each presents certain advantages and disadvantages.

Second, although the dialogue is set as a debate between two men whom we might call "gay" (Callicratidas) and "straight" (Charicles), it is clear that neither of them represents a common type of sexual being; rather, both of them are depicted as unusual, if not unique, in the exclusivity of their

tastes, and moreover, there is no Greek word or term that can be used to describe either of them because of those tastes. In fact, it is a mistake to think of them as having distinct sexual *identities* in the modern sense of the word. Callicratidas loves boys, but he is not labeled a “boy-lover.” He is not invested with particular physical, social, or emotional characteristics as a result of his preference. Rather, we should think of both speakers as expressing a *preference of personal taste*, no more and no less.

Some scholars have, nonetheless, pointed to Charicles’s arguments, in which he suggests that the love of boys is unnatural, as evidence that the ancient Greeks did express homophobia. But again, Charicles’s views are presented as unusual and extreme. By the same token, Callicratidas expresses severe misogyny in his description of the made-up and luxuriant women whom he prefers to avoid, and no scholars have suggested that his speech is representative of a pervasive Greek heterophobia. Although both their arguments rely on common philosophical and poetic ideas, there is nothing in the text that suggests that either of them is presenting the mainstream view when attacking the other.

Finally, we must discuss one of the great blank spots in the text, a part of this discussion that the dialogue simply refuses to deal with: What about women and their desires? Charicles discusses them briefly, in suggesting that women can feel pleasure in sex in a way that boys do not (or should not). But the text as a whole is simply unconcerned with what women think, feel, prefer, or desire. The erotic *subject* of the text is the adult male, and it is with his desires, pleasures, and preferences that the speakers are concerned. There is, however, one exception to this rule, and it is a telling one.

At the end of his argument, Charicles, the great lover of women, makes a bold and unusual move. If men are to love boys, he suggests, then we might as well take the further and, evidently, completely outrageous step of allowing women to love women:

Let them have intercourse with each other just as men do. Let them strap to themselves cunningly contrived instruments of lechery, those mysterious monstrosities devoid of seed, and let woman lie with woman as does a man. . . . And how much better that a woman should invade the provinces of male wantonness than that the nobility of the male sex should become effeminate and play the part of a woman. (*Erotes* 28)

Here, I suggest, the speaker is still not really concerned with the desires of women; rather, women are being set up as a bogeyman (so to speak) to terrify the reader away from the notion of male-male love. In particular,

Charicles seems hysterically concerned about the women's potential use of dildos ("those mysterious monstrosities devoid of seed"), further proof of the unnatural aspect of such love. But even more importantly, the passage is particularly alarmed at the idea of gender slippage. What is really upsetting about what we would call lesbianism is that one of the women will play the part of a man—that is, be the active partner in sex ("invade the provinces of male wantonness"). Bad though this is, it is not as frightening to Charicles as the possibility that a man, in male-male sex, should "play the part of a woman."

This last section, then, confirms what many scholars of ancient sexuality have been arguing for the last 30 years, namely, that the ancient Greeks are not concerned with homosexuality per se. What they are concerned with is a notion of masculinity that requires a man to be the active, penetrating partner in sex. To be a man (not a boy) who desires to be penetrated is, then, the non-normative position. For women, the opposite is true. Women are assumed to be passive by nature, and the non-normative woman is not criticized because she desires women, but because she desires to take on the active, penetrating role in sex. Thus for the Greeks, sexuality is closely bound to their understanding of gender roles.

MICHEL FOUCAULT AND *The History of Sexuality*

My reading of pseudo-Lucian's *Erotes* would not have been possible without the pioneering work of Michel Foucault. A distinguished philosopher and social critic, Foucault set out in the 1970s to write a history of sexuality. The first volume, which appeared in 1976, is a dense, theoretically sophisticated analysis of sexuality in its modern sense. While scholars are still arguing about the implications of much of this work, I will attempt a brief description of some of its main points.⁶ In 1984, the second volume (subtitled *The Use of Pleasure*) was published in French, and a translation into English followed swiftly. In this volume, Foucault began his analysis of the Greeks' discussions of sex, pleasure, and sexuality. Volume 3, *The Care of the Self*, published two years later, treats several works of Greek and Roman authors living under the Roman Empire.

To say that this history was controversial within the field of classics is a vast understatement. Scholars attacked Foucault on several fronts at once. Feminist scholars argued that Foucault, while profiting from their critiques of classical literature, had failed to cite much of their work.⁷ Others pointed out that Foucault's understanding of the classical world was deficient in several areas and that, in particular, he failed to distinguish be-

tween the different attitudes of Greece and Rome toward various sexual practices.⁸

Most important of all, however, some scholars took issue with Foucault's assertion that homosexuality, and indeed the entire discursive field currently thought of as sexuality *per se*, did not exist in ancient Greece and Rome—that it was, in fact, only possible to speak of sexuality with the advent of psychoanalysis in the nineteenth century. Today, this debate rages on, and many scholars (including Thomas Hubbard, whose source-book I referred to earlier) continue to argue for the existence of homosexuality as a sexual identity in the ancient world, with an accompanying homophobia. While I have read much of this controversy and considered it carefully, I should warn the reader that I am not an impartial judge in this matter. I have come to the conclusion that, in the main, Foucault was right: sexuality is a concept that is culturally specific and produced by a peculiarly modern form of discourse, and that we do not find homosexuality or homophobia in ancient Greece or Rome. Readers interested in the debate are encouraged to read Foucault and his detractors.

How can I argue that concepts as apparently pervasive as homosexuality and heterosexuality did not exist? First, it is important to distinguish between the raw fact of same-sex desire (which certainly did exist in ancient Greece and Rome, as it does today) and the idea that such desire constitutes one as a kind of person. Indeed, in the first place, the Greeks and Romans simply did not seem to be concerned about one's choice of love-object as a way of distinguishing sexual behavior. As Foucault wrote in volume 2,

As a matter of fact, the notion of homosexuality is plainly inadequate as a means of referring to an experience, forms of valuation, and a system of categorization so different from ours. The Greeks did not see love for one's own sex and love for the other sex as opposites, as two exclusive choices, two radically different types of behavior. The dividing lines did not follow that kind of boundary. What distinguished a moderate, self-possessed man from one given to pleasures was, from the viewpoint of ethics, much more important than what differentiated, among themselves, the categories of pleasures that invited the greatest devotion. To have loose morals was to be incapable of resisting either women or boys, without it being any more serious than that.⁹

In other words, it simply does not make sense to talk about Greek and Roman homosexuality when four conditions are true: (1) virtually every man is assumed to be interested in sex with boys; (2) this desire for boys

is not assumed, normally, to exclude an equally strong desire for women; (3) with rare exceptions (if any), the desire is depicted as that of an adult man for a so-called boy below the age of 20 or so, whereas a reciprocal desire between equals is considered rather strange; and (4) neither the Greeks nor the Romans have a word, or seem to have a category, for individuals who prefer sex with one gender rather than the other.

If the Greeks thought of sex in terms so different from our own, how did we get to where we are today? This is the subject, more or less, of volume 1 of Foucault's *The History of Sexuality*. The argument in this first volume is complex, closely argued, and contested. I can do no more here than provide a bare outline of some of the most salient points.

First, Foucault moves the subject of sexuality into the realm of history by arguing that the idea of sexuality itself—that is, the idea that each of us has a sexuality, a deeply held, private, and secret psychic reality that governs our sexual behaviors and inclinations—is not constant across time and space; rather, it came about because of a particular set of historical conditions. Seen through this lens, we—not the Greeks—are odd, and in fact, it does appear that the notion that one can divide the world up into homosexual, heterosexual, and bisexual is a particularly modern one.

Foucault points out that despite a tendency to believe that we are secretive about sex, in fact, the culture of the modern West is characterized by a drive to “confess” about sex. We talk to psychotherapists, to religious leaders, to parents, and to teachers; we take quizzes in supermarket magazines; daytime talk shows prominently feature unusual sexual relationships and are watched by millions of people. Foucault then argues that this confessional mode, which he argues has its roots in the early Christian church, makes certain assumptions about sex that have carried through to modern times. First and foremost, we seem to believe that one's sexual behavior and desire contain an essential truth about a person, but that this truth is by nature hidden and must be elicited through the intervention of a trained professional. Confession of this sexual truth will, ideally, bring about good effects, whether a cure of psychological deviancy or an assurance of salvation.

The other key aspect of the mode of confession, however, is that it always enacts a relationship of power between the confessor and the one extracting the confession. In its most extreme form, as under the Inquisition, this relationship can take on the brutality of physical torture. In less extreme forms, say, a young woman confessing her emotional desires to a guidance counselor, it is still true that the counselor is responsible for extracting the true confession, interpreting it correctly, and then helping the confessor to derive benefit from the act of talking about her desire.

Perhaps the boldest and most important theoretical move in Foucault's *History* follows: he argues that the modern practice of psychoanalysis, especially as described and practiced by Freud, follows this same model of confession, "constituted in scientific terms";¹⁰ that is, a patient goes to a psychoanalyst and confesses his sexual secrets to this trained professional. As before, there is a clear relationship of power: the psychoanalyst has the power, not only to interpret these confessions but also to extract the truth of them in the first place. In fact, the act of confession in classic psychoanalysis is much more than a mode of diagnosis. In Freud's fundamental first essay on sexuality, he argues that it is the repression of abnormal sexual desires that causes a patient to develop neuroses.¹¹ Once the sexual secret has been confessed and correctly interpreted, the act of bringing the secret truth of the subconscious mind to the level of consciousness removes the act of repression and cures the patient. Thus psychoanalysis has become the modern, scientific mode of confession.

It is within this context, of course, that the notion of homosexuality first came into being. Freud and his followers were concerned with what Foucault calls "a psychiatrization of perverse pleasure"; that is, the question for a psychoanalyst was not, is this sexual act or desire sinful? but rather, is this sexual act or desire healthy and normal? Unhealthy sexual desires, those that do not fit the norm were (and some still are) put into a scientific catalogue of types, and homosexuality became thought of as a sickness to be cured. More importantly, someone who exhibited this sickness became a type of person, similar to a schizophrenic or neurotic.¹² From this scientific recasting of the mode of confession, then, came the modern notion of homosexuality as constituting types of individuals, and indeed of sexuality itself, both normal and abnormal, as a fundamental aspect of a person's psyche.

Ancient Greece, as Foucault argues, does not exhibit this kind of discussion of sexual practice and desire; rather, the ancient Greeks thought of sexual desire as an appetite, best managed when it was kept under close control. But unlike the modern notion of perversity, to have this or that sexual desire did not, in most cases, mark one as a particular kind of person. When a man was marked by his sexual activity, it was not the case that the desire itself was thought of as inherently wrong (let alone sinful), but rather that some men were not in sufficient control of the desires to which all men were subject.

That does not mean, however, that the Greeks and Romans lived in a world free from moral valuation about sex—far from it. It is simply the case that their rules are not ours. In the first place, it is clear that numerous texts—legal oratory and Aristophanic comedy, most notably—do at-

tach negative values to certain kinds of sexual behavior. Adult men were not supposed to desire to be penetrated. To be penetrated was to accept a submissive stance in regard to the partner who was doing the penetrating—to give up, in other words, control of one's own body. That was never good, and it carried with it a much broader set of social and political connotations. As we observed when discussing pseudo-Lucian, the assumed *subject* of the sexual desire in that dialogue was an adult male, and neither speaker ever broached the idea that being penetrated might be preferable to penetrating; rather, their dialogue is about the advantages of the two acceptable kinds of sex for penetrating men such as themselves.

If normal men were assumed to be active, and desiring of both women and boys, then the boys who were their objects of desire were placed in an ambivalent position. Citizen boys in Greece were depicted as highly desirable objects. But at a certain age, such boys were expected to make a transition to full adulthood and cease being penetrated. Considerable anxiety shows itself not only about the future active citizenship of these boys but also about their integrity while still boys. The better the family, the more closely guarded the boy would have been, and it appears that actual *penetration* of a citizen boy was regarded as damaging to him. A man might, then, be criticized for damaging a boy in this way—or even brought to trial for *hybris*, a violation of the person, and a very serious charge. This criticism should not be confused with homophobia, however; such a man could have homoerotic sex freely with a prostitute or male slave without fear of reprisal.

Even the active adult man in an erotic relationship was not entirely free from constraint. One of the most important advances of Foucault's work (and of classicists John Winkler and David Halperin) was the understanding that the Greeks thought of desire in much the same way that they thought of other appetites: for food, for sleep, for physical comfort. While in some ways, this way of thinking makes sex less fraught with danger, in other ways, it locates exactly the danger that desire possesses. For, as Foucault showed through an analysis of various philosophical and medical texts, adult citizen men aspired to a state of *enkrateia*, or "self-control." Their control over their own bodies was thought of in ways analogous to their control over their households and wives, and to give in too readily to a desire—for food, for sleep, or for a boy or woman—indicated a lack of self-control that made a man suspect in other arenas, especially the political. Thus, as we will see, one of the most devastating things a man could do was prostitute himself. Doing so was a complete giving-over of self-control, and in fifth-century Athens, such a man could be stripped of his rights as a citizen.

When dealing with the sexual desires and acts of women, we must admit that we are at a severe disadvantage. Like every aspect of women's lives in ancient Greece and Rome, when it comes to sex, we have (almost) no first-person accounts. The vast majority of Greek and Roman literature was written by men, about men, and for men. When they do consider women, these male authors are frankly less concerned with the women as thinking and feeling subjects than as potential threats to the male subject. As such, though we can deduce what the Greek men thought was normal behavior—that is, behavior that fit into the male notion of femininity—we have to exercise considerable ingenuity to glimpse what the women themselves might have thought, felt, or done.¹³

From this masculine perspective, women were thought of as naturally lacking the kind of self-control that defines masculinity. As such, their sexual desires were often characterized as insatiable. For a woman to achieve the ideal of modest temperance—for which the most common word is *sophrosyne*—was to be chaste. Again, the discourse on love produced by pseudo-Lucian simply is not concerned with women's desires; there is no dialogue concerning whether it is better to have sex with a man or a boy (or with a man or a woman) from the point of view of a desiring woman. That is not the ethical or erotic position that the Greek texts concern themselves with. There is, however, a position of deviance from dominant norms for a woman, and we have seen it already: for women to be *active* in sex, that is, to penetrate, was considered deviant, as a denial of their natural gender role.

None of this, of course, is to say that the Greeks did not distinguish between sex with women and sex with boys. If that were the case, pseudo-Lucian's text could never have been produced. There are different rules governing these two kinds of desire, they have different characteristics, and it is even possible to find characters in the ancient world who express a strong preference for one over the other. But again, this preference is best thought of in terms of an appetite, not as a deep psychological trait that characterizes a certain type of person. It is a recognized difference, in other words, but not a meaningful one in terms of ethics, or values, or, in modern terms, sexuality.

SUMMARY: WAYS OF THINKING ABOUT SEXUALITY

There are different ways of thinking about sexuality that will be helpful to keep in mind in the following chapters. Various works present people who have certain kinds of sexual preferences, who are characterized in

certain ways by their sexual behavior, and who are occasionally described as having identities that are defined by their sexual practices. In looking at these people, it will be helpful to break what we usually call "sexuality" down into four related, but not identical, subcategories.¹⁴

First, does the person described have a sexual *orientation*? That is, does he express a strong or exclusive preference for erotic partners of a particular gender? Second, does the person have a sexual *identity*? Does her sexual desire mark her as a kind of person, and more importantly, does she think of herself as inhabiting that identity because of her particular kind of desire? Third, does the person have a sexual *morphology*: can he be spotted on the street as a particular kind of sexual being because of certain tell-tale signs in his physical being, including hairstyle, dress, mode of walking and talking, and the like? And finally, does the person analyzed demonstrate a particular *gender* role? Is she considered feminine or masculine because of the kind of sex that she prefers, and is the person's sexual behavior defined by whether she is active (penetrating, masculine) or passive (penetrated, feminine)?

When we think about the modern category of homosexuality, the answer to the first three of the preceding questions is probably a qualified yes. Sexual orientation is, for the modern West, the most basic aspect of homosexuality: gay men and women are defined as those who prefer sex with members of their own sex. We generally also think of this as an identity, an entire mode of life, and deeply held aspect of one's personal being. The third category is a bit trickier. Although it is commonly assumed that homosexuality results in demonstrable physical traits and personal characteristics, one of the things that homophobic people find most threatening about gay men and women is their apparent ability to blend into society and to appear straight. The final category, gender role, is one that does not apply directly to homosexuality; that is, a gay man can penetrate or be penetrated, can be effeminate or masculine in affect, and this has no effect on whether or not he is gay. For modern lesbians, the notion of penetrating or penetrated may well not apply at all.

In general, in the ancient world, the last category is the one that turns out to be most crucial: sexual actors are defined according to their gender role and according to whether they are penetrating or penetrated. On the other hand, the question of sexual orientation rarely, if ever, comes up. Most men were assumed to be interested in erotic objects of either gender. Most women were not thought about as sexual subjects at all. The other two categories, those of sexual identity and sexual morphology, are more slippery and will bear careful investigation in each of the texts that we encounter.

ANCIENT TERMS FOR SEXUAL BEHAVIOR

In reading almost any translation of a classical work that deals with sex, the reader will sooner or later stumble across examples that seem to directly contradict what I have just said. Translations of Aristophanes's plays or Catullus's poetry, for example, are full of jokes and insults against apparent homosexuality because their translators choose to render critical statements about certain kinds of people into modern slang terms such as *faggot*, or *bugger*, or *lesbian*. These passages echo the language of modern homophobia and make it sound as if the ancient Greeks and Romans thought of sex in the same ways that we do.

Unfortunately, what the reader must realize is that the translators of those texts are translating Greek and Roman sexual terms into terms from our own culture, and that in the process, a certain amount of distortion takes place. The fact of the matter is that the vast majority of these insults and jokes are directed against men who wish to be penetrated in sex, or women who are active in sex, "playing the part of the man." Very rarely, a man will be criticized for penetrating a boy, and if he is, it is generally not in terms that suggest that such action is in itself wrong—rather, he is criticized for damaging a wellborn citizen boy, or for failing to keep his desires in proper check, or (as in pseudo-Lucian) for engaging in nonprocreative sex. None of these insults, then, are attacks on homosexuality itself.

Following are a few of the words that are commonly translated into a modern sexual idiom:

erastes/eromenos: In the system of pederasty described above, in which an older man had an affair with a younger one, the older partner is referred to as an *erastes*, or "lover." The younger, passive partner is referred to by a word that is itself passive in form and can be translated as "beloved," namely, "eromenos." There is considerable controversy over how passive any given *eromenos* was, but the ideal was that he was younger, penetrated, and did not so much enjoy sex as endure it for the sake of the social relationship that his *erastes* offered him.

kinaidos: A *kinaidos* was a gender-variant man. He embodied several feminine characteristics, including a decadent style of dress and speech, a tendency to give himself over to physical luxury, and often (though not always) a willingness to be penetrated in sex. This term was taken up by the Romans (spelled *cinaedus*) and will be discussed at greater length in the second half of this study.

euryproktos: Literally, "wide ass," this is a term of reproach common in

the plays of Aristophanes. As the literal meaning of the word suggests, a man who was *euryprokotos* was given to being penetrated, often with a sense of having done so indiscriminately.

katapugon: Another Aristophanic insult, *katapugon* is of less clear origin and meaning than *euryproktos*. Often, it seems to mean simply “lecherous,” that is, given to indulging sexual desire. It may originally have had a meaning that referred to being penetrated but seems to have lost this sense by the Classical period (fifth century BCE).

tribas: In pre-Roman Greek literature, there is almost no discussion of women who prefer sex with other women; when Plato discusses such people (in the *Symposium*, discussed later), he uses an unusually rare word—*hetairistriai*—to name them. In Rome in the second century CE and later, however, we come across a more common term. A *tribas* is a woman who plays the active role in sex, usually with another woman. (In some Roman texts, *tribades* are said to penetrate boys.) Originally, the word appears to derive from a verb that has to do with rubbing or grinding. This word is often misleadingly translated as “lesbian.”

The tendency of modern translators to render all these modern terms in terms that invoke modern sexual categories is a clear impediment to understanding what goes on in the ancient texts. As a general rule of thumb, however, it is not a bad idea to mentally replace words that refer to our modern sexual system with words that describe the ancient one. When you run across the word *fag* in a comedy by Aristophanes, for example, simply think “passive” or, if you like, *kinaidos*. You will not often be wrong.